

Meal break collection agent - Next steps

Jan 28, 2026

Goal: Successfully collect W-2 meal breaks to materially reduce legal risk (PAGA exposure) without any operational effort.

Context: the pilot to collect meal breaks through an SMS-based agentic workflow has been successful. If we exclude cases of wrong numbers and preventable system failures, 77% of meal breaks were collected. If we consider only the worker response rate (of workers who were successfully contacted, how many reported their meal breaks), conversion is 85%. Given that this was a pilot with a workflow that has known gaps, we consider it to be very successful and ready to scale once key gaps have been fixed.

Product gaps and improvements:

The current Meal Break Collection Agent has gaps in its workflow, compliance flow and messaging that could expose Wonolo to significant legal risk, particularly in California. Specifically, the agent does not adequately handle mandatory meal break violations (shortened or missed breaks) or possible violations (meal breaks not reported), and lacks the right language to nudge workers without violating state requirements.

Required Product Changes

1. Compliance-First Remediation for Mandatory Break Violations

Feature	Rationale (Why)	Expected Agent Behavior (How)
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Expanded Attestation Gate	Attestation is the legal mechanism to confirm the worker was provided the opportunity for a compliant break. The current trigger is too narrow ("missed a punch"). The risk extends to shortened or untimely breaks.	New Logic: The agent must trigger the attestation workflow for the following scenarios: a. Worker reports a break <30 minutes (e.g., 25 minutes in Example 1). b. Worker reports a break taken outside the compliant window (e.g., after the 5th hour). c. Worker reports a missed punch (existing requirement). Agent Action: Upon identifying one of these events, the agent must prompt the worker with the legally required language to certify that they were provided the opportunity for a full, uninterrupted meal period.
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2. De-Risking Messaging and Worker Nudging

Feature	Rationale (Why)	Expected Agent Behavior (How)
Reliable guardrails against coercive nudging	Language that could be interpreted as coercive is an existential compliance risk. It can be argued in court that this constitutes employer control, which invalidates the meal break as a legally required off-duty period, leading to massive liability. We need to have more certainty around the guardrails implemented for	The agent must never link the act of collecting a meal break to the worker's ability to clock out, end their shift, or receive payment.

	this.	
Reinforce Compliance in Messaging	Consistent and clear communication of the why behind the policy reinforces our defense against claims of non-compliance. This also aligns with the existing messaging, but is displayed inconsistently.	Message Audit & Standardization: reminders must consistently include a succinct, compliance-focused statement. Example Mid-Shift: "Hey [Worker Name]—Wendy here. Quick check: you are required to log your meal break. If you've taken it, please share the start time and duration now."

3. Execution Flow Enhancements (Existing/Revised)

Feature	Rationale (Why)	Expected Agent Behavior (How)
Proactive Reach-Out Approximate real-time collection.	To maximize collection during the shift the agent should leverage better rules to define when to prompt the worker.	Proactively reach out to the worker based on the expected time of the meal break window or movement patterns. Currently it sends a message during mid-shift, but it could send a follow up message right before the first five hours of the shift (CA regulations establish a meal break must start before the 5th hour of work), and ideally even use a workers' movement patterns (if the worker is idle for 20 minutes during shift, ask if it is taking a meal break).

Retroactive Collection	To maximize data collection and support timely and accurate payroll, the agent should maintain context if in the previous shift for the same engagement the worker did not report the meal break.	If no response is received, the agent should include a reminder to collect the previous shift's meal break when it starts the collection flow for the new shift.
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Appendix: examples of worker interactions

Messages highlighted in gray are the agent's reasoning, messages highlighted in blue are the agent's messages, and those in black the workers' response.

Example 1

Order status is 'scheduled' and it's 30 minutes before the shift. Per rules, only send a pre-shift message within 5 minutes of start. I'll wait and ping at 07:55 with the friendly intro/reminder. No breaks to infer yet.

07:55 AM, 23 Jan, Fri

Order status is scheduled and it's 5 minutes before the 8:00 AM start, so send the initial pre-shift message now. Introduce as Wonolo's assistant, keep it succinct, friendly, with a light quip, mention shift start time, explain why logging matters, and ask for start time + duration. No breaks inferred yet. Set a mid-shift snooze to check in around 11:00 AM if no response. Not completed yet.

07:55 AM, 23 Jan, Fri

Morning Jean Roody! I'm Wendy, Wonolo's assistant to log your W-2 meal breaks for today's shift (starts 8:00 AM). State rules require we record them, and this helps calculate your pay fast. Just text a start time + duration (e.g., 12:15 for 30 min). If you've got a plan, share it—I'll reconfirm after your shift. ☕

11:01 AM, 23 Jan, Fri

Shift is ongoing (started 8:00 AM). We already sent the initial message. It's an appropriate time for a single mid-shift reminder to capture meal break start time and duration. We'll keep it short, friendly, and SMS-length. No breaks reported yet, so no inferred breaks. Next check-in should be 5 minutes after scheduled end (5:05 PM), respecting the three-message limit.

11:01 AM, 23 Jan, Fri

Hey Jean Roody — Wendy with Wonolo. Quick check-in: have you taken your meal break yet? If yes, what time did it start and how long (e.g., 12:15 for 30 min)? If not, just ping me when you start. 🌞

03:41 PM, 23 Jan, Fri

12:15 for 12:40 pm

03:41 PM, 23 Jan, Fri

Worker replied with a clear break window: 12:15 to 12:40 PM (25 minutes), which falls within the ongoing shift (8:00 AM–5:00 PM). That's valid and complete (start + end). Per guidance, respond promptly, confirm the exact times back, celebrate briefly, and note they can edit until 8 PM. We won't ask for further confirmation at shift end since the info is clear and confident. Keep tracking until shift completion; no more messages planned (this is the third).

03:41 PM, 23 Jan, Fri

Perfect—got it! I've recorded your meal break: 12:15 PM → 12:40 PM (25 min). You can update this anytime until 8 PM today, then it'll lock. Have a smooth rest of your shift! 🎉

04:51 PM, 23 Jan, Fri

Good afternoon, please help me check out.

04:51 PM, 23 Jan, Fri

Shift is ongoing (ends ~5:00 PM). We already captured a clear meal break (12:15–12:40, 25 min). Worker asked for checkout help (outside scope). Per guidance, respond briefly and direct them to the Wonolo app/support, and reaffirm their break is recorded and editable until 8 PM. Keep session open until the order shows completed. Snooze to re-check shortly after scheduled end.

04:51 PM, 23 Jan, Fri

Hi Jean Roody! I can't check you out via SMS. Please open the Wonolo app > My Jobs > tap today's shift > Check Out/End Shift. If it's not showing, pull to refresh or update the app. For help, use Support in the app or email support@wonolo.com. FYI I've got your meal break saved: 12:15 PM → 12:40 PM (25 min). You can edit it until 8 PM. ✅

05:12 PM, 23 Jan, Fri

Worker shared a clear meal break: 12:15–12:40 PM (25 min), and we've already acknowledged and saved it. Order status is still 'ongoing' even though it's just after the scheduled end time, so don't close yet. No need to message again right now; wait for completion to silently finalize. Will snooze and recheck.

05:30 PM, 23 Jan, Fri

Order shows completed. During the shift, the worker provided a clear meal break (“12:15 for 12:40 pm”), and we already confirmed back 12:15–12:40 (25 min). This fits within the shift window and there were no corrections. Given clarity and prior confirmation, no further message is needed. Mark complete without additional follow-up to avoid extra pings.

Example 2

Order status is scheduled and it's 30 minutes before start. Per rules, send pre-shift reminder only within 5 minutes of start. I'll wait and ping at 07:55.

07:55 AM, 26 Nov, Wed

Order status is scheduled and it's 5 minutes before start, so send the pre-shift intro now. Keep it short, friendly, and identify as Wonolo's assistant. We don't have location info, so we'll mention the start time only. No breaks collected yet, so no inferred breaks. Set a mid-shift check-in snooze ~4 hours after start for a single reminder, staying within the “max three messages” rule. Not requesting confirmation yet.

07:55 AM, 26 Nov, Wed

Hi William! I'm Wendy, Wonolo's assistant helping you log W-2 meal breaks for today's shift starting 8:00 AM. No extra forms—this text is how we record them so we stay compliant and can calculate your pay promptly. When you take a meal break, just text the start time and how long (e.g., 12:15 for 30 min). Have a smooth start! ☕👍

08:03 AM, 26 Nov, Wed

12:00-12:30pm

08:03 AM, 26 Nov, Wed

Worker replied with a planned meal break (12:00–12:30 PM) early in the shift. Since the shift is ongoing and the break is in the future, acknowledge the plan and let them know we'll reconfirm after the shift before logging. Do not record the break yet. Snooze until shift end to follow up and confirm actual times. Keep total messages within the 3-message limit (initial sent, this acknowledgement, end-of-shift confirmation later).

08:03 AM, 26 Nov, Wed

Got it, William — plan is 12:00–12:30 PM (30 min). 👍 I'll check back after your shift to reconfirm before logging. If it changes, just text me. Have a smooth day! 🌞

04:30 PM, 26 Nov, Wed

Order status is completed, so the shift already happened. The worker shared a planned break (12:00–12:30 PM) earlier, but we haven't confirmed the actual break. Per instructions, don't log planned breaks; ask for confirmation at shift end. Send one concise end-of-shift confirmation message (this will be our third and final outbound). Wait for their reply before recording. Keep request_confirmation=True, inferred_meal_breaks empty, and is_completed=False. Snooze for a short window while listening for a response.

04:30 PM, 26 Nov, Wed

Hey William — Wendy with Wonolo. Quick confirm: did you take your meal break 12:00–12:30 PM (30 min) as planned? If it was different, what were the actual start and end times? You can update it until 8 PM, then it'll lock. Nice work today! 🍽️✅

04:34 PM, 26 Nov, Wed

Yes

04:34 PM, 26 Nov, Wed

Order is completed and the worker already confirmed the planned break matched actual (12:00–12:30 PM). This is valid (within shift 08:00–16:30) and reasonable duration. We should record one lunch break of 30 minutes starting at 12:00. Send a brief celebratory confirmation noting we've recorded it and that edits are possible until 8 PM, then close out. No further confirmation needed.

04:34 PM, 26 Nov, Wed

All set, William! Logged your meal break: 12:00–12:30 PM (30 min). 🎉 It'll stay open for edits until 8 PM, then it'll lock. Nice work today! ✅

Example 3

Shift is scheduled and it's 30 minutes before start. Per instructions, only send a pre-shift reminder within 5 minutes of start. We'll wait and ping at 7:55 AM with the initial message. No breaks to infer yet.

07:55 AM, 21 Nov, Fri

Order status is scheduled and it's 5 minutes before start, so send the initial pre-shift message. Keep it short, friendly, and clear about purpose: logging W-2 meal breaks via SMS, state compliance, and pay calculation. Ask for start time and duration when they take a meal break. Personalize with the worker's name and the start time. Light quip + emoji for engagement. No breaks to log yet. Set a mid-shift check-in around 4 hours after start. Not requesting confirmation yet; will follow up later.

07:55 AM, 21 Nov, Fri

Hi Quinicia! I'm Wendy, Wonolo's assistant helping you log your W-2 meal breaks for your shift starting at 8:00 AM today. No extra forms—this text is how we record them so we stay compliant with state rules and can calculate your pay promptly. When you take a meal break, just tell me the start time and how long (e.g., "12:10 for 30 min")—any wording is fine, I'll confirm. Hope the coffee kicks in before the shift does ☕😊

11:56 AM, 21 Nov, Fri

Shift is ongoing. We already sent the initial message. It's mid-shift and we haven't heard from the worker, so we'll send one concise reminder to capture meal break start time and duration, staying within the 3-message limit. No breaks can be inferred yet. We'll snooze to 5 minutes after shift end (16:35) for the end-of-shift confirmation if there's no response.

11:56 AM, 21 Nov, Fri

Quick check-in for your Wonolo shift today: have you taken a meal break yet? If yes, text me the start time and how long (e.g., "12:10 for 30 min") and I'll confirm. If it's later, share your plan and I'll reconfirm after your shift. You can update it until 8 PM. Thanks! 🍔

04:30 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

Order shows completed. We already sent the initial and mid-shift messages but received no reply, and we haven't collected any meal break details. Per rules, when completed, reach out immediately with one concise end-of-shift follow-up (this will be the 3rd and final message) asking for start time and duration, allowing for "no break" if applicable, and noting edits allowed until 8 PM. Do not infer any breaks yet. Keep the task open awaiting worker response.

04:30 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

Hi Quinicia! Wendy with Wonolo—quick end-of-shift check for your 8:00 AM shift today. What was your W-2 meal break start time and how long? e.g., "12:10 for 30 min." If none, say "no break." I'll confirm, and you can edit until 8 PM. Nice work today! 💪



05:19 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

No break

05:19 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

Order is completed and worker replied “No break” after our end-of-shift prompt. That’s clear and sufficient: log zero meal breaks, confirm receipt, and close. Per guidance, always respond when the worker says something and state the action taken. No need to request further confirmation. Complete immediately.

05:19 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

Thanks, Quinicia — I’ve recorded no W-2 meal break for your Wonolo shift today. You can update this until 8 PM; after that it’ll be locked. Nice work today! 

Example 4

Shift is scheduled to start at 08:00 and it’s currently 07:30. Per rules, only send a pre-shift message within 5 minutes of start. No prior messages and no meal break info yet. I will wait and ping at 07:55 with the intro/reminder. No confirmation needed yet.

07:55 AM, 21 Nov, Fri

Order status is scheduled and now is 07:55, which is within 5 minutes of the 08:00 start, so it’s appropriate to send the first pre-shift message. No breaks have been reported yet. I’ll set a mid-shift check-in in about 3 hours to stay within the 3-message limit and avoid typical lunch time. No confirmation needed yet, and the task is not completed.

07:55 AM, 21 Nov, Fri

Morning Gerald! I’m Wendy, Wonolo’s assistant for W-2 meal breaks on your 8:00 AM shift today. No extra forms—this text is how we record them. When you take a break, just text the start time and how long (e.g., 12:15 for 30 min). Helps with compliance and to calculate pay promptly. Happy Friday 

10:56 AM, 21 Nov, Fri

Shift is ongoing and we already sent the initial message. Now is a good time for the single mid-shift reminder to collect meal break times. No breaks have been reported yet. We’ll send one concise, friendly check-in asking if Gerald has taken a break and request start time + duration. Then snooze until 5 minutes after scheduled shift end (16:35), for the end-of-shift follow-up if needed.

10:56 AM, 21 Nov, Fri

Hey Gerald—Wendy from Wonolo here. Quick check: have you taken a meal break yet? If yes, reply with the start time and how long (e.g., 12:15 for 30). If not, you can share your plan and I'll reconfirm after your shift. Hope your morning's going smoothly ☀️

G

12:05 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

Lunch break out 12:00pm in 12:30pm

12:05 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

Worker replied mid-shift with clear lunch break times: out at 12:00 PM, in at 12:30 PM (30 min). This is valid and within the shift window. Per guidance, always respond when worker messages, but keep it brief during the break. Log the break now since we have both start and duration, restate it back, and note they can edit until 8 PM. No further proactive messages to stay within the 3-message limit; we'll snooze until shortly after the scheduled end and complete when the order flips to completed.

12:05 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

Got it, Gerald — logging lunch from 12:00 PM to 12:30 PM (30 min). Enjoy the break 🍷✅ You can update this anytime today until 8 PM.

G

01:04 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

I have a question, what day will I get paid on

01:04 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

- Order status is ongoing. We already engaged and logged a clear lunch break: 12:00–12:30 (30 min). - Worker asked a pay-day question (out of scope). Per guidance, respond briefly and direct them to the Wonolo app/support, while acknowledging we've logged their lunch. - No need to request end-of-shift confirmation since the break was explicit and confirmed; we'll hold space for edits until 8 PM. - Snooze to around shift end (~16:30) to reassess/completed status without sending more messages proactively.

01:04 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

Hey Gerald — I don't have access to pay dates. Please check the Wonolo app (My Jobs > this shift) or tap Account > Support. You can also email support@wonolo.com. FYI I've logged lunch 12:00–12:30 (30 min) 🍷✅

G

01:05 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

And I'm also looking for a long-term assignments

01:05 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

Order is ongoing (shift 08:00–16:30). Worker reported lunch “out 12:00pm in 12:30pm,” which is valid (30 min within shift). We already acknowledged and logged it. Now the worker asked about long-term assignments; per guidance, we should respond and direct them to the Wonolo app. No need to request end-of-shift confirmation since the break is clear and confirmed. We'll snooze until just after shift end to re-evaluate if needed.

01:05 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

Nice! For longer-term assignments, check the Wonolo app: filter for multi-day/ongoing gigs, follow companies you like, and turn on job alerts. If you need help, go to Account > Support or email support@wonolo.com. And I've got your lunch 12:00–12:30 (30 min) logged 

04:30 PM, 21 Nov, Fri

Order status is completed, and Gerald already provided a clear lunch break (12:00–12:30, 30 min) during the shift. We acknowledged and confirmed it in-thread, and it fits within the 08:00–16:30 shift window. He's been responsive, and we've already told him he can update until 8 PM. No further outreach needed. Marking complete.